listed at the bottom led to a cryptic recording, which asked callers to leave a message for the nascent diplomatic mission. Curious onlookers debated in the cafes below: Was it a political statement? By the left, or the right? Could it ever come true?

In the United States, the Jewish community had spent months tearing itself apart over the agreement, which imposed restrictions on Iran's nuclear program in exchange for sanctions relief. Congressmen who supported it were slurred as self-hating Jews, even Nazi *kapos*. One might have expected a similar level of passion in Israel, where the prime minister had spent months portraying the deal as a harbinger of the second Holocaust. Yet the most striking thing about the Iran debate in Israel was the utter lack of one. The Knesset's dysfunctional foreign affairs and defense committee did not hold a single substantive hearing after the agreement was signed in July. Politicians like Isaac Herzog, the putative head of the opposition, read from the prime minister's talking points. With a crucial vote looming in Congress, Netanyahu jetted off to an expo in Milan to discuss sustainable agriculture.

"Let me put it very simply: There has not been any real discussion in this country on the subject," said Halevy, one of the few public figures to support the deal. "At the time the Congress is looking at every full stop and comma, the Israeli Knesset is on holiday."

Henry Kissinger once remarked that Israel has no foreign policy, only a domestic one. That aphorism has never been truer than in the Netanyahu age. The prime minister's opposition to the deal was well known. He repeated it at every turn, even invoking the specter of mushroom clouds over Tel Aviv in his response to a report on the high cost of housing. But his opponents believed he would ultimately lose the fight to block the deal in Congress. They muted their criticism, hoping to win favor with skeptical center-right voters, and to use Netanyahu's inevitable defeat against him. Lapid vowed to support Netanyahu "to the outside world, in English." Herzog went even further, saying there was "no daylight" between him and the prime minister on Iran. Ironically, their cynical ploy strengthened Netanyahu's position, giving the appearance of unanimous opposition to the deal. The prime minister even cited Herzog's support in an August address to the Jewish Federations of North America. "The man who ran against me in this year's election and who works every day in the Knesset to bring